Foragers locate fruits and mushrooms in a forest because evolution has organised forests according to a discernible organic order. Fruit trees photosynthesise, so they require sunlight. Mushrooms feed on dead organic matter, which can usually be found in the ground. So mushrooms are usually down at soil level, whereas fruits grow farther up. Another common rule is that apples grow on apple trees, whereas figs grow on figs trees. So if you are looking for an apple, you first need to locate an apple tree, and then look up. When living in a forest, humans learn this organic order.

It is very different with archives. Since documents aren't organisms, they don't obey any biological laws, and evolution didn't organise them for us. Tax reports don't grow on a tax-report shelf. They need to be placed there. For that, somebody first needs to come up with the idea of categorising information by shelves, and to decide which documents should go on which shelf. Unlike foragers, who need merely to discover the pre-existing order of the forest, archivists need to devise a new order for the world. That order is called bureaucracy.

Bureaucracy is the way people in large organisations solved the retrieval problem and thereby created bigger and more powerful information networks. But like mythology, bureaucracy too tends to sacrifice truth for order. By inventing a new order and imposing it on the world, bureaucracy distorted people's understanding of the world in unique ways. Many of the problems of our twenty-first-century information networks – like biased algorithms that mislabel people or rigid protocols that ignore human needs and feelings – are not new problems of the computer age. They are quintessential bureaucratic problems that have existed long before anyone even dreamed of computers.

BUREAUCRACY AND THE SEARCH FOR TRUTH

Bureaucracy literally means 'rule by writing desk'. The term was invented in eighteenth-century France, when the typical official sat next to a writing desk with drawers – a bureau.[19] At the heart of the bureaucratic order, then, is the drawer. Bureaucracy seeks to solve the retrieval problem by dividing the world into drawers, and knowing which document goes into which drawer.